

BRITISH PARLIAMENTARY DEBATE, POLARIZATION AND COLLABORATION

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Abstract: This paper explores the way that British Parliamentary Debate teaches collaboration to students and critics. In an effort to address rising polarization in the United States, BP debate is offered as a way to teach, and practice, collaboration. The paper explores the ways these skills are used by debaters and critics throughout the debate round, looking specifically at cooperation and consensus as tools to achieve collaboration. British Parliamentary offers distinct characteristics and rules, in contrast to other forms of debate, which lend itself to teaching these concepts throughout the debate.

Polarization in the American political climate has become prevalent in recent years. Conover et al. (2011) found individuals rarely interacted with someone of a different political ideology from themselves, even on social media. Mitchell and Wiesel (2014) noted that 63% of Republicans and 49% of Democrats said that “most of their friends share their political viewpoints” (p. 52). Page (2013) reported that in 2013 that Americans were noticing polarization, as 80% of Republicans and 73% of Democrats say American politics has become more divided in recent years. A survey of 10,000 adults nationwide found that these divisions are greatest among those most engaged in the process (Mitchell & Wiesel, 2014). Heatherington (2009) argued that the increase in polarization leads to policies that are ultimately more extreme than the public might otherwise support. Sunstein (2009)

concluded that a “lack of dissenting voices” allowed the United States to more easily enter the Iraq War (p. 41). This suggests there is a need for even those who are politically minded to learn from, and interact with, those of a different perspective to achieve more moderate policy actions in government.

Debate training is often offered as a solution to deal with extremism as it encourages discussion of current issues in a structured space. Mitchell (2011) contended public debate has the means to “cultivate wise judgment....informed by the give and take of argument exchange” (p. 64). Students can obtain this wise judgment while also cultivating other important skills. Debate is frequently offered as a solution to help students improve their public speaking, critical thinking and democratic skills (International Debate Education Association, 2014). Democracy requires that individuals be active participants, and this can be ensured by having students learn critical thinking, collaboration, communication and problem solving skills (Cohen, Pickeral & LeVine, 2010). McClenan (1985) wrote about the importance of integrating democratic skills and citizenship into the educational structure of our nation, as this emphasis has been lacking in the last century.

Collaboration has the ability to help solve partisanship as it turns differences from a deficit into a resource. The ability for different groups and viewpoints to work together breaks down one of the biggest problems of polarization today that individuals rarely interact with individuals who hold different viewpoints than their own. British Parliamentary (BP) debate has the potential to help solve this polarization problem by teaching collaboration to both students and critics in a debate format that rewards working with others. BP debate is one of the fastest growing formats

in the United States (Eckstein & Bartanen, 2015). BP debate features four teams in each round, with two advocating for the resolution, and two arguing against. Teams are labeled based on where they will speak during the debate with opening government (OG) speaking first, followed by opening opposition (OO), then closing government (CG) and closing opposition (CO). OG and OO are commonly called opening teams as they present first, and CG and CO referred to as closing teams as they wrap up the debate for their side. Each team features two members, each member gives a seven minute speech, and the speaking alternates between government and opposition (Johnson, 2009). All debaters focus on creating persuasive arguments for the average reasonable voter or the informed global citizen (World Universities Debating Championship, 2014).

British Parliamentary Debate has the potential to address the problem of polarization as it teaches students collaboration, an important quality to cross partisan lines and reach solutions. Hicks and Larson (2012) defined collaboration as:

A process through which people or organizations with diverse interests, backgrounds, and types of expertise work together to create new ways of understanding the causes of problems and to consider novel solutions to these problems. (p. 335)

Collaboration literature is split on whether collaboration creates or is a result of democracy. However, most agree that the two concepts are tied together (Grey, 1989; Lange, 2001; Snow, 2001; Zoller, 2000). Waugh and Streib (2006) wrote that collaboration is fundamental for a nation to properly address natural and non-natural disasters and used Hurricane Katrina as an example of

the failure of this practice. Collaboration occurs when individuals are open to different levels of culture, perspective, expertise, and ability (Davidson, 2011). In other words, difference is the point where collaboration can begin; different perspectives come together to accomplish common goals.

In this essay, I show how collaboration occurs for the debaters and the critics in BP debate. Debaters learn collaboration by cooperating with each other, developing relationships with fellow debaters, and allowing easy access for everyone to the debate. Critics learn collaboration by seeking consensus and a way to understand the round that is amicable and fair to everyone. I argue that BP debate creates students who understand collaboration and that collaboration is an important quality for a democratic citizen to be equipped to think beyond today's partisan realities. Although, debate cannot solve all the problems that polarization presents, BP debate produces more responsible citizens who are better equipped to collaborate across party lines. First, students engage in cooperation using extension-creation, points of information (POIs), and clash. Second, critics engage in collaboration which is encouraged by the roles of the chair and the wing judges, the use of lay judges, and the ranking system.

Debaters and Cooperation

Cooperation is the beginning of collaboration. Students need to form connections and relationships with others to be able to move forward in seeking a solution. These differing opinions can be valuable for collaboration. Everyone has blind spots and weaknesses, however when we work together we can surmount these and seek solutions (Davidson, 2011). BP mirrors a real world of stakeholders vying for a finite resource

(the ballot). Yet, despite this antagonistic environment, debaters come together and cooperate. Cooperation occurs in a BP debate through the model, the extension, the shared burden of points of information (POIs) and, finally, clash.

First, BP debate encourages and rewards a simple, straightforward model that allows ample opportunity for all teams to debate. A model is the way in which the debate will be carried out and the vehicle through which it is debated. If a resolution provides the topic for the debate, a model sets the parameters. For example, I watched the Canadian Novice Fall Open where the resolution was to require mandatory vaccinations. Instead of a team doing a tricky move, like making a debate about one specific and controversial vaccine such as Gardasil, BP debaters would choose to talk about all major vaccinations to better address topics like government mandates and bodily autonomy instead of the medical merits of a specific vaccine. In the round I watched, the opening government team did not provide any exceptions based on religion or personal beliefs, instead they proposed that vaccinating everyone was so important they would be willing to do so even to those with personal or religious qualms. This team even claimed they would make vaccinations free in order to make it possible for everyone to be vaccinated easily. By providing funding, the OG ensures that the debate doesn't become distracted by arguments about cost and instead can focus on fundamental issues, like bodily autonomy and government mandates. By not providing any exceptions, the OG kept this round simple and about the core issue. This predictability helps all teams easily cooperate throughout the rest of the round, as it is easy for everyone to understand what the debate is about.

In another round that included exceptions the

debate could have become about the purpose of exceptions, why exceptions exist, and if exceptions are needed, thus changing the focus of the debate from vaccinations to government exceptions. By introducing a predictable model, the OG allows the rest of the debaters to easily engage in a debate that they expected to occur thus allowing all teams to cooperate throughout the debate. In other formats of debate rounds can often devolve into who can create a tricky, complex argument that will make others in the round confused or unprepared, however BP rewards predictability and is often a race to the center, where the core of the issues lie. This predictability helps promote cooperation as all teams are able to easily engage in the debate. Students can apply this outside of the debate round by starting a conversation in a way that allows everyone to easily engage everyone else in the conversation, which is the starting point of collaboration.

The extension, an argument that Closing Opposition (CO) or Closing Government (CG) makes that is distinctly different than arguments made earlier in the round, is another place that teams learn cooperation. The CO and CG rely on opening teams (Opening Government and Opening Opposition) to determine the best new arguments to present. The primary role that CO and CG are expected to fulfill are to provide an extension, an argument or contribution to the debate that is substantial, relevant, and different from what has already been said. The opening team should have provided and detailed the basic arguments for the debate and established the ground that each team has. The closing team's extension will deepen and move the debate forward, by providing new analysis, evidence or arguments. In this way, closing teams are dependent on opening teams to have fulfilled their role so they can

provide deeper arguments.

For instance, if an Opening Government (OG) team has done a good job proving the economic benefits of lifting the embargo with Cuba, a strategic closing government team might choose to make their extension about the benefits, and likelihood, of democratization. This extension takes the debate in a new direction distinct from the top half, but furthers the OG's arguments that economies will be open and prospering, a (arguably) prerequisite for democracy to take hold. Thus, the CG and CO rely on the OG and Opening Opposition (OO) to provide basic fundamental arguments, so that they can fulfill their role and deepen the debate. Further, the OG and OO rely on the CG and CO to move the debate in a new direction, to show that they have done a satisfactory job making their arguments. Each team relies on the others to help make their arguments successful within the debate. While not direct, this cooperation, by fulfilling their roles of introducing quality, straight-forward arguments, teaches students that you must be willing to work together and build upon each other's arguments to begin seeking solutions. BP teaches students to take ideas, solutions and arguments and look for ways to make them better and more persuasive by acknowledging and building upon ideas already presented by others.

Next, points of information (POIs) encourage interaction and participation from debaters throughout the round, teaching students that cooperation, and collaboration, is often a long process that requires engagement. In BP debate both questions and rejoinders are delegated to POIs. In a POI, a speaker may do one of three things: ask a question, respond to a point, or bring up a point you previously made or will make in future speech (World Universities Debating Championship, 2014). Speakers must stay engaged

and develop relationships with other teams to allow the debate be its strongest, this often occurs through POIs, which allows for the debate to have the best arguments presented in the clearest way.

The speaker has the discretion to determine when and from whom to take a POI. Despite the fact that there are not formal rules requiring POIs, most tournaments encourage about two per speech (Johnson, 2009). Critics notice when a speaker does not take any POIs. If a team intentionally excludes another team from asking a POI, then they are often penalized by the judges. Moreover, teams are likely to develop strong relationships among their colleagues that could result in more POIs. For example, when I was competing, my partner and I developed a rapport with a few teams that we saw frequently at various tournaments. We came to trust these teams, knew they would provide good arguments for the debate, and that they would provide insightful and provoking questions. In the same regard, these teams often took the POIs that I was offering in reciprocation.

Allowing time in your speech for other debaters to offer POIs often leads to receiving more POIs during other speeches. This reciprocity shows the importance of building relationships, seeking cooperation by inviting others to participate in your speech, and providing reasonable and relevant POIs. Cooperation is often not an easy process, it requires allowing other people to share their ideas and question yours. BP encourages students to see this as part of the process of seeking conclusions. Collaboration requires engagement for extended periods of time to fully understand each other, and BP rounds require the debaters to be engaged, taking and receiving POIs, for the entire 60 minute round. This ability to view interaction and relationships as a positive and imperative part of the

collaboration process is a lesson students can apply to disagreements outside the debate round. POIs also give opportunity to engage in productive conversation to work across traditionally antagonistic lines (the opposition) to participate in a multi-way conversation. Despite the fact that there are only seven minutes per speaker, it is still expected that each speaker take about two POIs per speech. Each POI is no more than 15 seconds in length, thus, 30 seconds of your speaking time is given to someone else. The POI might suggest something wrong with the arguments or contain requests that another argument or point be addressed. This teaches students that the opportunity to speak and share opinions is not a monologue, but a multi-way conversation. Because critics look down upon teams that do not take POIs or don't offer them, students understand that engaging throughout the debate is just as important as what you say in your speech. It can be easy to view questions or critiques in a POI as a reflection you're your arguments are not strong and to quickly dismiss the individual asking the POI. However, the best response to a POI is thoughtful and responds to the concerns raised. Moulton (1983) described the dangers of looking for ways to make quick responses to anything the opposition might say as the adversarial method. This method views anyone on the opposition as your adversary that needs to be defeated, a problem when seeking solutions. By encouraging POIs throughout the debate, BP teaches students that questions and critiques from others are not a bad thing, in fact they are important to seeking collaborative solutions.

Finally, BP places a strong emphasis on clash which helps teach students dialogue by fostering interaction among a variety of different perspectives. Clash is an argument's ability to interact, respond, and compare

to other arguments in the debate. Clash teaches the melding of world views as it requires teams to engage with each other's arguments, instead of presenting their case as a monologue. The best BP debates occur where contentious and controversial arguments are made by each speaker, and there is significant evaluation and discussion of an individual's arguments compared to others' arguments. This is important as the debate requires students to engage directly with the arguments that are counter to their side. Tannen (2012) claimed "if you parry individual points - a negative and defensive enterprise - you never step back and actively imagine a world in which a different system of ideas could actually be true" (p. 274). By promoting clash and emphasizing the importance of engagement, students learn how to consider other viewpoints and how your arguments might fit with, or clash with, others and why this is true. A poorly constructed speech that lacks clash negatively impacts the whole round, as each speaker would have less material to respond to and compare their arguments to. BP requires students to be ready to debate any issue on any side (assignments are posted just before the round begins), and not agreeing with the motion is not reason enough to lack material. Forcing students to think about how the might present all arguments, not just the ones they agree with, forces them to expand their ability to empathize and relate, or at the very least articulate, views they might not personally agree with. In each speech, the presentation of strong, clashing arguments allows the other participants engage in the debate with equally strong arguments. Thus, the students to begin to consider and question how to evaluate the issue and how to reach a conclusion.

I judged a round at Northwest College that exemplifies this reliance on previous speakers' quality

of arguments to ensure others' argument quality. The resolution was: This House would file share with a clean conscience. The debate was likely to center around music and artistic downloads on sites such as LimeWire. But, the first speaker had no arguments about these issues and instead talked vaguely about access to knowledge. The OO, had difficulty responding to the case because they agreed with the majority of the OG's arguments, thus, their refutation was limited and lacking substance. The rest of the round struggled to gain substantial content and identify the points of clash because each speech prior lacked arguments with substance and significance. This means that a productive dialogue did not occur because all relevant opinions/arguments were not presented. If a point is consistently being debated in the round, often the team that introduced that argument is rewarded because critics find identifying a key point of clash and introducing it to the debate. In BP debate clash is not a negative, in fact ample conversation and discussion about your arguments means that you've identified a fundamental point of the debate. As Sunstein (2009) pointed out, when people refuse to hear others perspectives, they become more polarized. BP debate requires students to interact with, and sometimes even present, arguments they might not personally agree with. At the very least, a student has at least been exposed to differing opinions, which can help combat increased polarization.

BP allows opportunities for students learn and practice collaboration. From the start of a BP debate, students are thinking about others in the round by creating a straightforward, easy to engage with model. As the round continues, CO and CG will provide an extension that relies and expands upon the arguments made by the OO and OG. Throughout the

debate students engage in POIs, teaching them that collaboration is frequent and allows for the best ideas to be drawn out; additionally, students will engage in clash allowing their perspectives to be opened to different ideas. This same ability can be translated to the issue of polarization as today's students rarely interact with someone of a different partisan viewpoint. If this student begins to understand that cooperation is important, they will hopefully be willing to listen to others and collaborate to reach productive solutions.

Critics and Consensus

Collaboration is best achieved when judges use consensus decision making. This allows everyone involved to feel fair and amicable to the conclusion. It's important to recognize what consensus is not, it is not having one group or individual win while another loses, nor is it taking a vote and going with a majority. Consensus is a process of seeking to synthesize all perspectives and use them to reach a solution. Some formats of debate become exclusive and reward technical jargon and arguments that don't appeal to the general public. Eckstein and Bartanen (2015) write that BP frames topics as public problems, soliciting the reasonable citizen to determine solutions. Using Goodnight (2012), Eckstein and Baranen (2015) understand that public interests extend well beyond those of a private individual and the highly exclusive concerns of a technical sphere. In this sense, BP aims to make itself accessible to anyone, of varying backgrounds and educational levels. Consensus can only be reached when multiple, varying perspectives are welcomed and valued at the table. BP debate fosters consensus by allowing anyone to participate easily in the process, and thus allow the most diverse and fair decisions to be reached. This section will explore how BP teaches students consensus: first, by looking at the

role of the wing critics; second, by understanding lay judges; and, finally, by exploring the ranking system.

Consensus judging requires critics to come to agreement about what happened within the round. Consensus judging puts multiple critics (often three) in a room and designates one the “chair” and the others “wings.” It is the chair’s responsibility to facilitate the discussion among critics as they attempt to reach a decision. The critics then discuss the merits of each team and assign teams a numerical rank of 1 through 4, “1” for the team that debated the best and a “4” for the team that did the worst. Instead of critics each making individual decisions, all critics must agree on one ranking for all teams. In contrast to other formats of debate, where the judge is basically a lone wolf, BP debate encourages judges to work together, talk out problems, and evaluate the round collaboratively to reach the best possible choice. Collaboration requires a place where everyone feels their voice can be heard, and the chair is tasked with creating that environment during adjudication.

The chair is typically someone with extensive experience and knowledge of how BP debate works. The chair’s opinion is not more important than other critics’ opinions; the role of a chair is to not say what is right or wrong but instead to facilitate and encourage a space of discussion (World Universities Debating Championship, 2014). Often the best chairs are the ones who know how to encourage the wings to feel comfortable sharing their opinions. At the Calgary Novice Fall Open, in a round where I was a wing critic, our chair was a well-known critic from the Canadian circuit, who had been successful as a debater and critic domestically and internationally. He was qualified and likely to have a strong opinion about the rankings, however he kept quiet and focused on facilitating

discussion. He identified the four major arguments that happened throughout the debate and the discussion centered on which team had most successfully won each argument. Later the chair went speech by speech and asked us all to identify the most important element, argument, or contribution. With this process, all critics had a clear understanding of what had happened, what each speaker had contributed, and who we thought deserved top rankings. Throughout the adjudication process, our chair was aiming to increase understanding and meld the different views among the wings by encouraging a discussion and finding different ways to evaluate what happened in the debate. The chair often has more experience and perspective, and can use this to help guide the decision. But, more importantly, they encourage a discussion of the round. Therefore, BP uses a distinct judging approach that exemplifies the need for discussion when faced with opposing opinions and using that discussion to begin to reach consensus.

The adjudication process for BP requires multiple judges to discuss the debate after the round in order to reach a consensus decision, thus teaching the debaters that discussion and conversation are vital to reach a decision. The wing critics provide an important role in the adjudication process by providing different perspectives. The purpose of having wing judges is to ensure that all arguments and speakers have ample opportunity to have the points heard as each judge has a different background and thus offers a different perspective that could contribute to the way the round is evaluated. Having multiple critics ensures that someone will hear an argument that another might have missed or understood differently. Making sure that the entire debate is taken into account, and allowing for the occasional human error, shows the importance of multiple perspectives when seeking

consensus. Consensus cannot be reached by simply taking a vote, or assuming that most people will agree with an opinion, instead consensus requires people with differing opinions and perspectives to come together and reach a decision collectively.

Consensus is also encouraged by allowing debate experts and ordinary citizens to judge debates. In a tournament, critics are recruited by the teams attending and must meet the standard of average reasonable voter or the informed global citizen (World Universities Debating Championship, 2014). Because BP is designed to appeal to the average person, anyone can easily judge a round with little knowledge of debate jargon or lingo, which creates more space for a diverse judging pool. The variety of critics' backgrounds encourages competitors to offer arguments that are easily accessible to the public. As a result, debaters avoid complex lingo and fast speaking paces that could potentially turn off unfamiliar critics. Instead, there is a focus on making persuasive, well presented arguments. This ability to make arguments accessible allows for the critics to be able to reach a consensus decision as they are all able to understand and engage with the arguments presented. Recognizing that all critics need to be able to understand and evaluate the arguments, makes debaters more aware of the need to make your arguments easily understood and accessible by everyone. Accessibility and ensuring that people of all experiences and skill levels can participate in the conversation is vital to democracy and helping curb polarization which tends to leave individuals feeling left out.

In other formats of debate, students lose their eligibility to compete once they judge at a competition. BP allows students to compete as well as act as critics. This ability to switch back and forth between

competitors and judge requires a closer and more peer-like relationship between competitors. Indeed, today's competitor might be tomorrow's critic. The ability to switch roles encourages cooperation and collaboration across the divide between judges and competitors. This is important to reaching consensus as consensus requires that each individual perspective and position is taken into account to reach an amicable conclusion for everyone. Teaching that roles can change based on circumstances shows that in democracy we may sometimes hold different roles, such as parent, stakeholder, or victim. These roles can change frequently. BP offers the opportunity to accept and recognize that roles change frequently. It encourages students to engage each role to the fullest, whether the role be debater or critic.

Finally, BP debate encourages consensus by shifting the framework away from a win-loss format and towards evaluating which argument demonstrates the most effective solution. By contrast to other forms of academic debate, in BP there are multiple teams affirming or negating, which fundamentally reorients the meaning because it relies on a system which ranks teams first through fourth place (World Universities Debating Championship, 2014). BP introduces an ever fluctuating coalition between those who are a political friend or foe. Teams are not only trying to defeat the opposition, they are trying to defeat the opposition better than the other team on their bench. For example, as the OG, you could potentially beat out your CG team, through the help of CO. If CO is able to effectively defeat all the arguments that CG brings to the table, it makes them look weak, however this could make your arguments look stronger if they are still standing. This means that those who might have traditionally been seen as your opponent can actually help you in

certain situations. Viewing the opposition as an ally in some situations is unique to BP debate and further distances itself from traditional models of academic debate as the sides and opposition are less defined with four teams in the round. This ability to recognize the ways that other parties could help you is fundamental to reaching consensus because consensus is focused on reaching a conclusion that includes all viewpoints. By viewing your opposition as a potential ally, you open up the potential for more diverse solutions that might not otherwise be considered. Consensus is often achieved by working to seek a solution in concert with those you might otherwise be opposed to. BP debate requires students to look for allies in the round in an unlikely place, the opposition. Cultivating the ability to view others as partners in forming conclusions, rather than as adversaries to beat, is what makes BP uniquely suited to teach consensus as a way to collaborate with unlikely allies.

Reaching consensus decisions is an important skill that students can learn from BP debate. This section has explored how consensus occurs through the adjudication process, by exploring the role of a chair and a wing critic, as well as adjudication requirements, in addition to exploring the ranking system of decisions used in BP. If students can begin to think of their opinions and political perspectives as something they can offer to the group in order to reach consensus that is amicable for everyone, then we can begin to move beyond gridlock and polarization toward collaboration for meaningful solutions.

Conclusions

BP debate inculcates collaboration and is uniquely situated to address the growing partisan gap in our nation by training citizens to engage in productive,

meaningful conversations with those from many different political viewpoints. Both critics and students participate in a debate format that fosters collaboration. BP debate teaches students these skills in a way they won't learn abstractly in the classroom. By practicing, debaters and judges become much more likely to translate these skills beyond the debate and into their personal opinions and perspectives. When students understand how to engage in a respectful, meaningful debate they can use these same techniques to talk to someone of a different political party. The problem of partisan polarization cannot be solved through BP debate alone. However, BP can produce citizens who are more prepared to interact in the public sphere. Additionally, more research is needed to determine how students are applying these skills outside of debate rounds. Regardless of whether students and critics use the specific skills outside of debate, BP generates familiarity with these concepts which can benefit debaters later in life. BP's focus on teaching collaboration uniquely offers students the opportunity to gain skills essential to democratic deliberation while debating and judging.

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